and now I'm a working photographer, fighting to preserve the freedom of these majestic animals. And feeling freer in the process.

More ironic, I was filming veterinarians as they put tracking devices on the animals. (The devices would help researchers better understand the herd's migration patterns.) Until now, I didn't have the happiest associations with tracking devices.

One day we filmed a vet dart a big bull elephant, then wrap a tracking collar around his neck. But the dart only nicked the elephant's tough skin, so he was able to gather himself and charge away.

Mike yelled: *Grab the camera, Spike! Run!*

The elephant was tearing through thick bush, mostly along a sandy path, though sometimes there was no path. The vet and I tried to stay in his footprints. I couldn't believe the animal's speed. He went eight kilometers before slowing, then stopping. I kept my distance, and when the vet caught up, I watched him put another dart into the elephant. Finally the big fella went down.

Moments later Mike came roaring up in his truck. *Good job, Spike!*

I was panting, hands on my knees, bathed in sweat.

Mike looked down in horror. *Spike. Where are your shoes?*

Oh. Yeah. Left them on the truck. Didn't think there was time to grab them.

You ran eight kilometers…through the bush…in no shoes?

I laughed. *You told me to run. Like you said, the Army taught me how to take direction.*

28.

RIGHT AT THE TURN OF the new year, 2009, a video went viral.

Me, as a cadet, three years earlier, sitting with other cadets.

At an airport. Cyprus, perhaps? Or else maybe waiting to fly to Cyprus?